

Lecture 2

The Rhetorical Situation

Definitions

Rhetoric (*noun*)

1. the art of effective or persuasive speaking or writing, especially the use of figures of speech and other compositional techniques.
2. language designed to have a persuasive or impressive effect on its audience, but often regarded as lacking in sincerity or meaningful content.

More simply:

- 1. speaking or writing that's intended to persuade**

The Rhetorical Situation

- The **rhetorical situation** is the context in which communication takes place. It consists of five key elements:
 1. Exigence: the issue or situation that prompts someone to write, speak, or act
 2. Audience: the intended recipients of the communication
 3. Purpose: the goal the communication hopes to achieve
 4. Constraints: factors that limit the communication, such as time, location, or medium
 5. Context: other factors that influence the communication

There are a lot of other lists like this that add, remove, or alter these items, but we'll use these for this course.

Exigence

Exigence / exigency (*noun*)

1. The quality of requiring immediate aid or action

Communication	Exigence
Passengers are sent a text notification that their flight is cancelled	Passengers need to be notified so that they can change their travel plans
A company is responding to a request for proposals with a written proposal	The buyer needs to know what the company can offer to meet their needs
An engineer asks a clarifying question about a term in a document	The engineer needs to understand what the term means so that they can avoid making mistakes

Mundane Exigence

Not all exigencies are high stakes or complicated.

- A data scientist writes a progress report so their boss knows what they have worked on
- A professor distributes a syllabus so that students have clear expectations of the course
- A weather app provides forecasts because users need to know if they should wear a coat

Audience

The audience is the group or groups that receive and interpret a message. Any message may have multiple audiences:

- The **intended audience**, the group who the speaker *intends* to receive the message
 - The **primary audience**, the main group the communication is directed toward
 - The **secondary audience**, others who may hear or read the message
- The **unintended audience**, other groups who receive the message

Purpose

Purpose is the **reason for the communication**. There are many different purposes:

- To inform
- To persuade
- To entertain
- To motivate
- To instruct
- To document

Purpose

The help identify the purpose, think of the **intended outcome** of the communication

- For a project proposal, the purpose might be to get approval to do the project (to persuade)
- For a newspaper article, the purpose is to communicate some recent event (to inform)
- For this lecture, the purpose is to help you understand the rhetorical situation (to instruct)

Constraints

Constraints are the limitations, obstacles, or factors that influence how a communicator can respond to the exigence and achieve their purpose.

As with audience and purpose, there are many types of constraints

- Audience constraints
- Context constraints
- Speaker constraints
- Format constraints
- Cultural constraints

Constraints

- Audience constraints relate to the audience themselves
 - A technical audience demands more details and specialized language
 - An audience of children has a short attention span
- Contextual constraints relate to the environment the communication takes place in
 - Delivering this lecture pre-recorded limits interaction
 - Talking at a concert requires you to speak loudly and use short sentences

Constraints

- Speaker constraints are limits on the speaker's expertise, credibility, or resources
 - The speaker may have a limited understanding of a topic
 - The speaker may belong to a social group that impacts their credibility
- Format constraints are limits placed by the type of communication
 - Text messages have to be short (or at least they used to)
 - Written reports do not allow questions in real-time
- Cultural constraints are limits given by the communicators' culture(s)
 - In Japanese business culture, you do not disagree openly in a meeting

Context

Context is a useful “other” term describing other factors that influence a communication

- Recent events
- History between the speaker and the audience
- Timing of the communication

Contextual items can often be thought of in terms of the constraints they impose

Knowledge Check

- For each of these situations, identify the exigence, audience, purpose, constraints, and context
 1. A keynote presentation by a vice president of Amazon at an AWS re:Invent conference
 2. A progress status update from a data scientist about a project they are working on
 3. Sharing a meme with your friends in a group chat
 4. Telling your relatives what you're studying in school at a family event
- One of these situations will be your quiz (to be completed on Canvas)